



THE LITERATIUM COMPANION · VOLUME II

A SLOW TRAVELLER'S GUIDE

Colombia

SIX REGIONS · ONE COUNTRY · MANY STORIES



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Colombia is not one country but six — held together, when it is held together, by a river that runs through all of them, and by the stubborn conviction that the story is worth the telling.

— FROM THE HOTEL LIBRARY



THE ANDES
ABOVE THE
CAUCA
VALLEY,
BEFORE THE
CLOUD COMES
DOWN



A HILLSIDE VILLAGE IN THE COFFEE AXIS, LATE AFTERNOON

CHAPTER ONE

A Note on Colombia

I

The shape of the country, and the shape of this book. What we are not attempting.

"Colombia is the country that has everything, and has not yet decided what to do with it."

Colombia is the second-most biodiverse country on earth. It has two oceans, three mountain ranges, two great river basins, an Amazon frontier, a Caribbean coast, a Pacific coast, and an archipelago in the Caribbean Sea. It has more bird species than any other country — almost two thousand — and more species of orchid, more species of butterfly, more species of frog. It is, in geographical terms, an embarrassment of riches.

It is also a country that has spent much of the last half-century being misunderstood from the outside. The image of Colombia in the foreign imagination has been, for too long, a single image: drugs, violence, a country not to be visited. That image is now twenty years out of date. The Colombia that a traveller meets today is safer, more welcoming, and more varied than the headlines ever suggested. It is also — and this is the point of this book — a country that rewards the slow visitor in ways that few countries do.

This is not a complete guide to Colombia. It is a companion — a series of introductions, organised by region and by theme, written for the kind of traveller who has come to Mompox and is beginning to think about what else the country might hold. The chapters that follow cover the six natural regions; the literary and musical culture; the food and the coffee; the wildlife; the festivals; and the practical matter of getting around safely and well. There is, at the end, a short reading list — because Colombia is, before anything else, a country of books.

What we have not attempted: restaurant reviews, hotel recommendations (beyond the occasional personal note), itineraries that can be completed in a week, or anything resembling a checklist. Colombia cannot be checked off. It can only be returned to.



A FEW ORIENTING FACTS

AREA · 1,141,748 KM²

Roughly the size of Spain, France, and Portugal combined. The fourth-largest country in South America.

POPULATION · ~52 MILLION

The third-most populous country in Latin America, after Brazil and Mexico.

CAPITAL · BOGOTÁ

At 2,640 metres. The third-highest capital in South America, after La Paz and Quito.

LANGUAGES

Spanish (official); 65 indigenous languages; English in San Andrés and Providencia; Creole in Palenque.

BIRD SPECIES

~1,920 — more than any other country on earth.



FROM THE ANDES TO THE CARIBBEAN — A
COUNTRY OF HORIZONTAL GEOGRAPHIES

CHAPTER TWO

The Six Regions

II

Colombia is not one place. It is six — Caribbean, Pacific, Andean, Orinoquía, Amazonia, Insular. Each has its own climate, its own food, its own accent, its own music.

"In Colombia, to travel two hundred kilometres is to change country."

— A COLOMBIAN FRIEND, IN CONVERSATION

The standard geographic division of Colombia recognises six natural regions. They are not administrative — the country is divided into thirty-two departments — but they are the regions that Colombians themselves speak in. To go from one to another is to change altitude, climate, food, music, and the colour of the light.

What follows is a brief introduction to each, with the cities and landscapes that a slow traveller might consider. The introductions are deliberately short. The point is to give a shape, not a survey.

THE CARIBBEAN · THE COAST OF THE NORTH

The Caribbean coast is where most travellers begin — Cartagena, Santa Marta, Barranquilla, and the desert peninsula of La Guajira to the east. It is hot, loud, musical, and famously hospitable. Cartagena's walled old town — a UNESCO World Heritage site since 1984 — is the country's most photographed neighbourhood. Santa Marta is the gateway to the Tayrona National Park, where the mountains meet the sea. Barranquilla throws the country's greatest carnival, four days before Ash Wednesday. The coast is the home of cumbia, vallenato, and champeta; it is the home of García Márquez, whose fictional Macondo sits somewhere between here and the swamp.

THE PACIFIC · THE GREEN WALL

The Pacific coast is the country's least-visited region, and one of its most extraordinary. The Andes drop sharply into the sea; the rainfall is among the highest on earth; the population is overwhelmingly Afro-Colombian, descended from people who escaped slavery in the colonial centuries. The cities — Buenaventura, Nuquí, Bahía Solano — are small and functional; the coast itself is a line of beaches, mangroves, and rainforest. Humpback whales arrive from Antarctica to breed between July and October. The music is the *currulao*, the marimba-driven sound of the Pacific. This is the region for the traveller who has been everywhere else.

THE ANDEAN · THE SPINE

The Andean region is the Colombia most people picture: the three cordilleras (Western, Central, Eastern) that run north from the Ecuadorean border, the high plateau of Bogotá, the Coffee Axis, the cities of Medellín and Cali. It is the most populous region, the most economically active, and the most varied. Bogotá is the capital — high, cool, literary, and serious. Medellín is the City of Eternal Spring, a city that has remade itself in the last twenty years. Cali is the salsa capital. The Coffee Axis — Quindío, Caldas, Risaralda — is the heart of the coffee country, and the home of the Cocora Valley and the wax palm, the national tree.

THE ORINOQUÍA · THE PLAINS

The Orinoquía — Los Llanos — is the great savanna east of the Andes, drained by the tributaries of the Orinoco. It is cowboy country: cattle, horses, the *llanero* culture, the music of the harp and the *cuatro*. Villavicencio is the gateway; the rest is open sky, slow rivers, and the

largest remaining populations of jaguar in the country. The region is overlooked by almost every traveller. That is, for the right kind of traveller, the reason to go.

THE AMAZONIA · THE GREEN NORTH

The Colombian Amazon — the southern wedge of the country, south of the Orinoquía — is the least populated region. Leticia, on the Amazon river, is the only town of any size; from there, by boat, you enter the rainforest. The pink river dolphin, the giant otter, the macaw, the jaguar — all are here. The national park of Amacayacu is the most accessible; Chiribiquete, the largest, is a UNESCO site closed to general tourism. The Amazon is not easy, and it is not cheap, but it is — for those who go — unforgettable.

THE INSULAR · THE ISLANDS

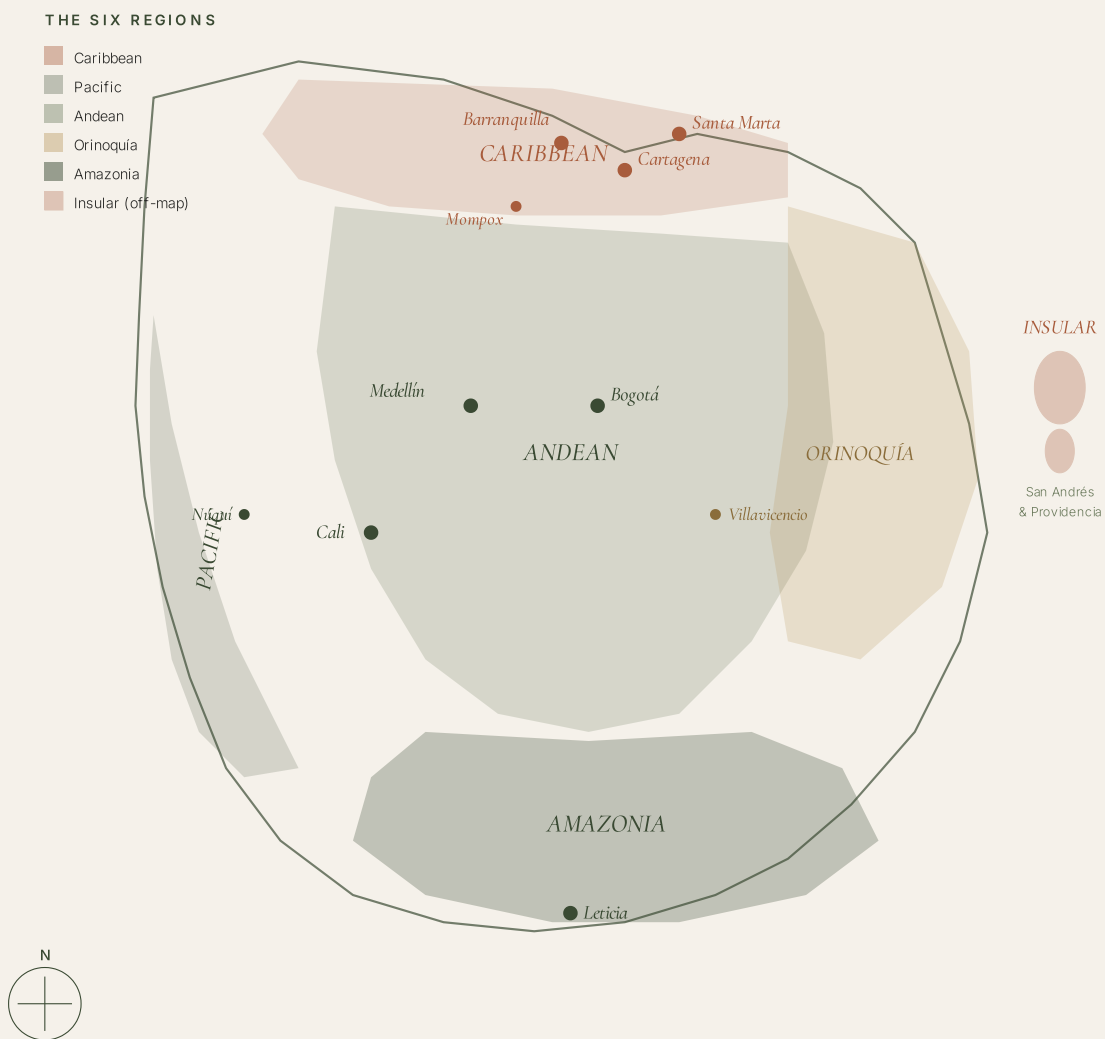
The Insular region is the archipelago of San Andrés and Providencia, in the Caribbean Sea, seven hundred kilometres off the coast. San Andrés is the larger, more developed, more visited; Providencia is the smaller, quieter, more beautiful. The islands are English-speaking Raizal territory; the culture is more Caribbean than Colombian. The sea is the colour the postcards promise.



THE SIX REGIONS

A country in six parts

The natural regions of Colombia — Caribbean, Pacific, Andean, Orinoquía, Amazonia, Insular — and the cities that anchor them.



A schematic — not to scale. The Insular region (San Andrés and Providencia) lies approximately 700 km off the Caribbean coast, here shown inset at right.



A READING TABLE, AN AFTERNOON IN THE HOTEL
LIBRARY

CHAPTER THREE

Culture

III

A country that reads itself. Literature, painting, the art of conversation — the soft infrastructure of Colombia.

"Many years later, as he faced the firing squad, Colonel Aureliano Buendía was to remember that distant afternoon when his father took him to discover ice."

— GABRIEL GARCÍA MÁRQUEZ, CIEN AÑOS DE SOLEDAD

Colombia is, before anything else, a country of books. It is the country of Gabriel García Márquez, who won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1982, and whose *Cien Años de Soledad* — *One Hundred Years of Solitude* — has sold more than fifty million copies in forty-six languages. But García Márquez is the beginning, not the end. The Colombian literary tradition is long, deep, and still very much alive.

The literary culture is centred on Bogotá, which was named a UNESCO World City of Literature in 2007. The city's book fair, the Feria Internacional del Libro de Bogotá, is one of the largest in the Spanish-speaking world. The bookshops of the Candelaria — the old colonial centre — are among the best in the continent. Librería Lerner, on Calle 15, has been selling books since 1894.

Beyond García Márquez, the names to know are these. Álvaro Mutis, the poet and novelist, whose *The Adventures and Misadventures of Maqroll* is one of the great under-read works of the late twentieth century. Fernando Vallejo, the difficult, brilliant, controversial novelist of *Our Lady of the Assassins*. Laura Restrepo, whose novels — *Delirium*, *The Dark Bride* — are among the finest literary thrillers in the language. Héctor Abad Faciolince, whose memoir *The Oblivion We Shall Be* — about the murder of his father by paramilitaries — is one of the indispensable books of modern Colombia. Juan Gabriel Vásquez, perhaps the most celebrated Colombian novelist of the generation after Gabo, whose *The Sound of Things Falling* is the great novel of the drug-war years.

Painting, too. Fernando Botero — the painter of the rounded figures — is the country's most visible artist, with museums in Bogotá, Medellín, and Cartagena. But the deeper tradition runs through Alejandro Obregón, Édgar Negret, Doris Salcedo — whose installations have filled the Turbine Hall at Tate Modern — and the extraordinary legacy of the caricaturist Ricardo Rendón, who drew the country into being in the early twentieth century.

The conversation, though, is the real art. Colombians are, by reputation and in practice, a conversational people. The long lunch. The afternoon coffee. The slow evening. The story that takes two hours to tell. This is not a matter of folklore. It is the texture of the culture, and the reason a slow traveller is rewarded here in ways that a fast one is not.

In a bookshop on Calle 15, a man in a grey jacket reads for an hour without buying anything. The bookseller does not mind.



BEYOND BOTERO

01 **MUSEO DEL ORO, BOGOTÁ**

The Gold Museum — the single greatest collection of pre-Columbian goldwork in the world. The Muisca raft, on the top floor, is worth the visit alone.

02 **MUSEO DE ARTE DEL BANCO DE LA REPÚBLICA, BOGOTÁ**

Botero, Obregón, Grau, Negret — the canonical Colombian twentieth century, in a beautiful modernist building.

03 **CASA MUSEO GARCÍAS MÁRQUEZ, ARACATACA**

The birthplace of Gabo — a modest house, restored, in the small town where Macondo was born. Two hours from Santa Marta.



A COLOMBIAN TABLE — REGIONAL DISHES, SHARED

CHAPTER FOUR

Food

IV

The country is large; the kitchens are many. A short tour of the regional table — from ajiaco to bandeja paisa, from lechona to mojoyoy.

"In Colombia, lunch is not a meal. It is a structure on which the day is built."

There is no single Colombian cuisine. There are six — one for each region — and within them dozens of local variants. What unites them is a respect for the long lunch, the sharing of the table, and the principle that food is a social act before it is a nutritional one.

The *ajjaco* of Bogotá is the dish that visitors learn first: a chicken and potato soup, thick with three kinds of potato, a handful of corn on the cob, the herb *guascas*, a spoonful of cream, a few capers. It is served with avocado and rice on the side. It is the dish you eat on a wet Andean afternoon, in a small restaurant in La Candelaria, and it is perfect.

The *bandeja paisa* of Antioquia is the dish visitors learn second. It is enormous: rice, red beans, ground beef, chicharrón (fried pork belly), a fried egg, ripe plantain, chorizo, avocado, arepa. It is the lunch of the people of the mountains, the meal that carried a farmer through a day of work. It is not to be attempted at dinner. Order it at lunch, do not order a starter, do not order dessert, and walk for an hour afterward.

The coast has its own table. *Cazuela de mariscos* — a seafood stew in coconut milk. *Arroz con coco*. *Patacón*, the twice-fried green plantain that comes with everything. The fish — pargo rojo, lebranche — grilled whole, with lime. The *arepa de huevo*, a fried cornmeal pocket with an egg inside, from Cartagena. The *queso costeño*, the salty fresh cheese that you crumble over your arepa.

Los Llanos gives us the *mamona* — the *ternera a la llanera* — a whole young calf roasted over an open fire on a spit, for a crowd, on a Sunday. The Pacific gives us *encocado* — fish or prawns in coconut sauce, with plantain. Tolima gives us *lechona* — a whole roast pig stuffed with rice and peas, served with a cornmeal cake called *insulso*. The Amazon gives us *mojojoy* — the grub of the palm weevil, roasted, eaten by hand, tasting of coconut. (This last is not for everyone. But it is a dish, and it is part of the country.)

Dessert is a separate matter. *Arequipe* — what the rest of Latin America calls dulce de leche — is the national sweet, eaten with a spoon from the tin. *Obleas* — two thin wafers with arequipe between. *Postre de natas*. *Cuajada con melado*. The *dulces de Mompox*, of which the Volume I Companion has already spoken. And everywhere, the fruit — the staggering, almost embarrassing abundance of tropical fruit, of which Colombia has more varieties than any country should reasonably claim: mamey, zapote, guanábana, níspero, lulo, maracuyá, granadilla, badea, curuba, tomate de árbol, the list does not end.



FIVE THINGS MOST VISITORS MISS

BEYOND THE BANDEJA

01 **AJIACO SANTAFEREÑO, IN BOGOTÁ**

The real thing — with guascas, three potatoes, and a side of avocado and rice. Order it at lunch on a wet day.

02 **TAMAL TOLIMENSE, ON A SUNDAY MORNING**

Cornmeal, pork, chicken, rice, pea, wrapped in a banana leaf and steamed for hours. Eaten with chocolate and bread.

03 **SANCOCHO DE GALLINA, ANYWHERE ON THE COAST**

A hen stewed with plantain, yam, and corn. The cure for everything, including the heat.

04 **AREPA DE HUEVO, FROM A STREET CART IN CARTAGENA**

Fried cornmeal pocket, egg inside, eaten standing, with a soda. Breakfast.

05 **A GLASS OF LULADA, IN CALI**

Lulo, blended with water, sugar, and lime. The taste of the afternoon.



A COFFEE FINCA IN THE ANDES, THE RED CHERRIES
READY FOR PICKING

CHAPTER FIVE

Coffee

V

The Eje Cafetero — the Coffee Axis. The wax palms of Cocora. The slow wet processing, the morning cup, the literature it has made.

"Coffee in Colombia is not an industry. It is a landscape, a memory, and a way of being in the morning."

— A COFFEE FARMER

The Colombian coffee region — the Eje Cafetero — runs along the central and western cordilleras, between one thousand and two thousand metres of altitude. In 2011, UNESCO inscribed the Coffee Cultural Landscape on the World Heritage List, citing criteria (v) and (vi): a living cultural tradition of exceptional value, and a landscape that embodies the marriage of human settlement and ecological possibility. The region produces some of the finest mild coffee in the world.

The Coffee Axis is the heart of it — the departments of Quindío, Caldas, and Risaralda. The landscape is steep, green, and intensely cultivated: coffee bushes under the shade of plantain and guamo trees, the red cherries picked by hand in two annual harvests. The farms — the *fincas* — are small, often family-run for three or four generations. Many now accept visitors, and a night or two on a working finca is one of the great Colombian experiences.

The towns of the Coffee Axis are the country's most beautiful. Salento, in Quindío, is the most visited — a small grid of brightly painted houses, a plaza, a view of the mountains, and a road that leads up to the Cocora Valley. Filandia, less visited, is arguably more beautiful. Jardín, in Antioquia, is a long way from anywhere and worth every hour of the journey. Marsella, Jericó, and Aguadas are quieter still. All of them share a quality that is increasingly rare: they are towns that have not been remade for the visitor. They are towns that the visitor has been allowed to enter.

The Cocora Valley is the emblem of the region — a high valley, often in cloud, dotted with the wax palm, *Ceroxylon quindiuense*, the national tree of Colombia and the tallest palm in the world, growing to sixty metres. The palms rise out of the grass at impossible heights, their pale trunks like columns in a green cathedral. The walk through the valley is six hours, and it is one of the great walks in the country.

A woman in rubber boots carries a basket of red cherries down a steep path, one hand on the back of a mule.

But coffee is not only landscape. It is also labour, and the labour is exact. The cherries are picked by hand, selectively, only the ripe ones. They are depulped, fermented, washed, and dried in the sun. The drying is slow — twelve to twenty days on raised beds, depending on the weather. The bean that results is dense, complex, and — in the cup — bright. Citrus over caramel, a clean acidity, a long finish. The Colombian profile is one of the most recognisable in the world, and it is the product of the altitude, the soil, the cloud, and the care.

The Hotel Literatium's house coffee comes from Huila, the department to the south of the Coffee Axis, which has emerged in the last two decades as one of the country's finest single-origin regions. The cup, in the morning, on the terrace in Mompox, is the same cup every morning — and it is, by design, the point of the morning.

"The finca I grew up on had three hundred trees. My grandfather knew each one by name. I do not mean metaphorically. He had names for them."

— A COFFEE FARMER NEAR PITALITO, HUILA

COFFEE TOWNS · FIVE FOR THE SLOW TRAVELLER

BEYOND THE OBVIOUS SALENTO

01 **SALENTO, QUINDÍO**

The gateway to Cocora. Touristed, but the colour of the houses, the view from the mirador, and the road to the valley justify it.

02 **FILANDIA, QUINDÍO**

Twenty kilometres from Salento, half the visitors, twice the charm. The view from the mirador, at the blue hour, is the picture of the coffee country.

03 **JARDÍN, ANTIOQUIA**

A long way from Medellín — four hours by road — and worth every minute. The plaza, the church, the mountains behind. Stay two nights.

04 **MARSELLA, RISARALDA**

Small, quiet, beautiful. The kind of town where the afternoon lasts exactly as long as it should.

05 **JERICÓ, ANTIOQUIA**

The birthplace of Santa Laura Montoya. A steep town, a green town, a town of cafés and churches and the slow life.



ACCORDION, DRUM, AND GUACHARACA — THE
INSTRUMENTS OF VALLENATO

CHAPTER SIX

Music

VI

Cumbia, vallenato, joropo, currulao, champeta. The sound of Colombia is not one sound. It is a great overlapping conversation between the coast, the mountains, and the forest.

"Music in Colombia is not background. It is the foreground, and the conversation, and the architecture of the room."

Colombian music is not a single tradition. It is a set of overlapping traditions, each rooted in a particular region, each carrying the inheritance of the people who made it — indigenous, African, European, and the long slow mixing of all three. A traveller who learns to recognise the principal forms will hear the country differently.

Cumbia is the great sound of the Caribbean coast. Its roots are in the music of the enslaved Africans brought to the ports of Cartagena and the lower Magdalena, mixed with the indigenous gaita flute and the European drum. The rhythm is a loping 2/4, the melody carried by the gaita or the accordion. Cumbia is the music that travelled — to Mexico, to Argentina, to Peru — and became, in those places, something else. In Colombia it has remained what it was: a music of the river and the coast, played at night, danced in pairs, the women with candles, the men behind.

Vallenato is the music of Valledupar, the city at the foot of the Sierra Nevada de Santa Marta. It is built on three instruments — the accordion, the *caja vallenata* (a small drum), and the *guacharaca* (a scraped bamboo tube) — and the songs are stories: long, narrative, romantic, sometimes funny, sometimes tragic. The great vallenato composers — Rafael Escalona, Alejo Durán, Emiliano Zuleta — are national figures, and the Festival de la Leyenda Vallenata, held in Valledupar each April, is one of the country's great gatherings. In 2015, UNESCO inscribed vallenato on the List of Intangible Cultural Heritage in Need of Urgent Safeguarding — a recognition of both its value and its vulnerability.

Joropo is the music of Los Llanos — the plains of the Orinoco. It is fast, virtuosic, built on the harp, the cuatro, and the maracas. It is the music of the cowboy, the llanero, and it is the closest thing Colombia has to a national folk tradition. The Festival Internacional del Joropo, in Villavicencio, is held each year in November.

Currulao is the music of the Pacific coast — the marimba de chonta (a wooden xylophone), the drums, the call-and-response singing. It is Afro-Colombian music, closely related to the marimba traditions of Ecuador and the Pacific coast of Central America. UNESCO inscribed the marimba music of the Pacific in 2015 on the Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage. The Festival Petronio Álvarez, in Cali each August, is the great gathering of Pacific music.

Champeta is the music of Cartagena — a modern sound, born in the poorer neighbourhoods in the 1980s, mixing African soukous and Haitian compas with local sounds. It is loud, joyful, and deeply local. **Salsa**, though imported, has become Cali's music — the city is the salsa capital of the world, and the Feria de Cali, each December, is the great salsa festival. **Reggaetón**, born in Puerto Rico but made global from Medellín, is the contemporary sound of the country — for better and for worse, depending on whom you ask.



LISTEN · A SHORT PLAYLIST

IF YOU HAVE ONE EVENING

CUMBIA

Los Gaiteros de San Jacinto — "Cumbia Cienaguera". The original, the root.

VALLENATO

Alejo Durán — "La Creciente". The song of the rising river, the song of Mompox.

JOROPO

Los Llaneros — "Caballo Viejo". The song of the old horse, the song of the plains.

CURRULAO

Grupo Naidy — "Currulao". The marimba, the drum, the call. The Pacific.

SALSA

Grupo Niche — "Cali Pachanguero". The song of the city. Play it loud.



THE ANDEAN CONDOR — THE NATIONAL BIRD, OVER
THE HIGH CORDILLERA

CHAPTER SEVEN

Wildlife

VII

From the Andean condor to the pink river dolphin. The most biodiverse country per square kilometre on earth.

"In Colombia, the natural world is not a backdrop. It is the room itself."

— A BIOLOGIST

Colombia is, by most measures, the second-most biodiverse country on earth — and, per square kilometre, the most biodiverse. It has more bird species than any other country (almost two thousand), more orchids, more butterflies, more amphibians. It has jaguar, puma, spectacled bear, tapir, two species of crocodile, four species of sea turtle, the pink river dolphin, the giant otter, the giant anteater, the Andean condor. The list does not end. The traveller does not need to see all of it. The traveller needs to understand that it is here.

The wildlife is organised by region, because the regions are ecosystems. In the Andes, the spectacled bear — *Tremarctos ornatus*, the only bear in South America — lives in the high cloud forest, on the slopes of the páramo. The Andean condor — *Vultur gryphus*, the national bird — soars over the highest peaks, in the Los Nevados and El Cocuy parks. The condor is rare; the bear is rarer; to see either is a privilege.

The Caribbean coast has its own fauna. Howler monkeys in the dry forest of Tayrona. Iguanas on every wall. Manatees in the Cispatá bay, south of Cartagena — one of the largest remaining populations on the Caribbean coast of the continent. Sea turtles nest on the beaches of Tayrona and La Guajira between March and August; the park rangers will tell you where to walk.

The Pacific coast is the great cetacean coast. Humpback whales — *Megaptera novaeangliae* — arrive from the southern ocean to breed between July and October, with a peak in August and September. Nuquí and Bahía Solano are the bases; the whales can be seen from the beach, but a boat trip will get you among them. Sea turtles nest on the Pacific beaches too — five species, including the giant leatherback. The mangroves of the southern Pacific hold the American crocodile and the birdlife of the Chocó rainforest, one of the wettest places on earth.

The Orinoquía is the plains of the cowboy and the cat. The capybara — the world's largest rodent — is here in large numbers. The giant anteater, the ocelot, the puma, and — most importantly — the jaguar, the largest cat in the Americas, which has in Los Llanos one of its last strongholds. The Casanare region is the place to go; the ranches that take visitors are few, and the experience is unforgettable.

The Amazon is, well, the Amazon. The pink river dolphin — *Inia geoffrensis*, the boto — is the most beloved. The giant otter — *Pteronura brasiliensis* — is the most endangered. The jaguar is here too, in the largest numbers in the country. The macaws — blue-and-yellow, scarlet, red-and-green — fly over the rivers in the early morning. The monkey species are too many to list. Amacayacu National Park, upriver from Leticia, is the most accessible; Chiribiquete — the largest national park in Colombia, a UNESCO mixed natural and cultural site since 2018 — is closed to general tourism, and is one of the great unexplored places on the planet.

The birdwatcher should plan the trip with care. Colombia has more bird species than any other country, but the birds are spread across the regions and the seasons. The Bogotá savanna has its endemics — the bogotá rail, the silvery-throated spinetail. The Santa Marta mountains — an isolated massif on the Caribbean coast — have more endemic species per square kilometre than anywhere else in the continent. The Chocó rainforest has the toucan barbet, the long-wat-

tled umbrellabird, the baudo guan. The Coffee Axis has the multicoloured tanager, the yellow-eared parrot. A serious birding trip to Colombia can yield five hundred species in two weeks. The casual birdwatcher will see a hundred in a morning, and will be very happy.



FIVE THINGS MOST VISITORS MISS

BEYOND THE OBVIOUS

01 THE HUMPBACK WHALES OF NUQUÍ

July to October. The Pacific coast. The whales breach in the bay, fifty metres from the beach. There is nothing like it.

02 THE PINK RIVER DOLPHIN, AT AMACAYACU

The boto. Pink. In the black-water tributaries of the Amazon. Up close, from a canoe.

03 THE WAX PALMS OF COCORA, AT DAWN

Not wildlife — but the trees, sixty metres tall, in the morning cloud, are alive in a way that few landscapes are.

04 THE SPECTACLED BEAR, IN LOS NEVADOS

Rare. But there. A high cloud forest, a long walk, a small chance, a great reward.

05 THE MANATEES OF CISPATÁ BAY

South of Cartagena. A boat, a guide, a slow morning. The manatee is gentle, large, and almost gone. Here, it survives.

The most biodiverse country per square kilometre

A small selection of species by region — and the numbers that put Colombia at the top of the global table.

BY THE NUMBERS

1,920

BIRD SPECIES

More than any other country.

456

MAMMAL SPECIES

Fourth in the world.

~800

AMPHIBIAN SPECIES

Third in the world.

59

NATIONAL PARKS

14% of the national territory.

ANDEAN

Andean condor

Vultur gryphus · national bird

Spectacled bear

Tremarctos ornatus

Multicoloured tanager

Chlorochrysa nitidissima

CARIBBEAN

Howler monkey

Alouatta seniculus

Green iguana

Iguana iguana

Antillean manatee

Trichechus manatus · Cispotá

PACIFIC

Humpback whale

Megaptera novaeangliae · Jul-Oct

Leatherback turtle

Dermochelys coriacea

Long-wattled umbrellabird

Cephalopterus penduliger

ORINOQUÍA

Jaguar

Panthera onca · Casanare stronghold

Capybara

Hydrochoerus isthmius

Giant anteater

Myrmecophaga tridactyla

AMAZONIA

Pink river dolphin

Inia geoffrensis · the boto

Giant otter

Pteronura brasiliensis · endangered

Scarlet macaw

Ara macao

INSULAR

San Andrés anole

Anolis concolor · endemic

Providencia black crab

Gecarcinus ruricola

Coral reef fauna

Seaflower Biosphere Reserve

FIVE NATIONAL PARKS TO KNOW

Tayrona · Santa Marta

The mountains meet the Caribbean.

Amacayacu · Amazon

The great flooded forest, upriver from Leticia.

Chiribiquete · Amazonia/Orinoquía

UNESCO mixed site 2018. The largest park. Closed to general tourism.

Los Nevados · Coffee Axis

The high páramo. The spectacled bear. The condor.

El Cocuy · Boyacá

Glaciers. The highest trekking in the country.



A CARNIVAL DANCER, BARRANQUILLA, BEFORE THE
SUN IS HIGH

CHAPTER EIGHT

Festivals

VIII

The calendar of the country. Barranquilla, Medellín, Valledupar, Cali, Pasto, Mompox. The great gatherings, when the towns spill into the streets.

| *"A festival in Colombia is not an event. It is a flood."*

Colombians find reasons to gather. The calendar is full of festivals — music, flowers, coffee, saints, jazz, fireworks, dance. The six that follow are, for the slow traveller, the most rewarding. Each is worth a journey. Each will fill the town; book well in advance.

Carnaval de Barranquilla, four days before Ash Wednesday — in 2026, the 14th to the 17th of February. UNESCO inscribed the carnival on the Representative List of Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2008 (originally proclaimed a Masterpiece in 2003). It is, after Rio, the second-largest carnival in the Americas. The costumes, the dances — the *marimonda*, the *congo*, the *garabato* — the music, the four days of it, the heat, the noise, the joy. Barranquilla is not, otherwise, a tourist town. For the carnival it is the centre of the country. Go. Stay somewhere quiet. Sleep in the afternoon. Dance at night.

Feria de las Flores, Medellín, late July to early August. The Flower Festival — a week of *sil-leros* (flower farmers from the high villages above the city) carrying enormous wooden frames of flowers on their backs, down into the city, in the great parade on the final Sunday. The whole city is in flower. There are antique cars, horse parades, music, and a general mood of celebration. Medellín in August is mild, green, and at its best.

Festival de la Leyenda Vallenata, Valledupar, late April. The great vallenato festival — three days of competitions in the four vallenato airs (*son*, *puya*, *merengue*, *paseo*), the king of vallenato crowned, the great accordionists playing into the night. Valledupar is hot, and the festival is loud, and the music is everywhere. For the visitor, this is the deepest entry into the music of the coast.

Petronio Álvarez, Cali, mid-August. The Festival de Música del Pacífico — the great gathering of the Pacific-coast music, the *marimba* and the drums. Three days of concerts, free, in the open air. Cali in August is warm, the festival is joyful, and the music is unlike anything else in the country. UNESCO inscribed the *marimba* music of the Pacific on the Representative List in 2015.

Carnaval de Negros y Blancos, Pasto, 28 December to 6 January. The Blacks and Whites carnival — UNESCO, 2009. A great street festival, with a day when people paint themselves black (5 January) and a day when they paint themselves white (6 January), floats, music, and the great parade of the 6th. Pasto is in the deep south, near the Ecuadorean border; it is high, cold, and beautiful. The carnival is the great Andean festival of the south.

Festival Internacional de Jazz de Mompox, September. Free, open-air, four nights. Forty thousand visitors in a town of forty thousand. The 2025 edition was the eleventh. For the guest of Hotel Literatium, this is the festival of the house — and the one for which we most recommend a return visit.

A boy in costume sits on a curb, eating an *arepa*, waiting for the parade to reach his street.



A LOOSE ANNUAL PLANNER

JANUARY

Carnaval de Negros y Blancos, Pasto (28 Dec – 6 Jan). UNESCO.

FEBRUARY

Carnaval de Barranquilla (4 days before Ash Wednesday). UNESCO.

MARCH–APRIL

Semana Santa, Mompox and Popayán. Processions.

APRIL

Festival de la Leyenda Vallenata, Valledupar.

AUGUST

Feria de las Flores, Medellín. Festival Petronio Álvarez, Cali.

SEPTEMBER

Festival Internacional de Jazz, Mompox.

DECEMBER

Feria de Cali. Salsa.



THE ROAD THROUGH THE ANDES — SLOW,
BEAUTIFUL, OCCASIONALLY UNNERVING

CHAPTER NINE

Safety & Transport

IX

*The plain things, in plain language. How to get around. What to be careful of.
What not to worry about.*

"Colombia is safer than its reputation. It is not safe enough to be careless."

— FROM THE FOREIGN OFFICE ADVICE

At El Dorado, the immigration officer stamps your passport without looking up. The taxi rank is outside. The road into Bogotá is wide, grey, and high.

Colombia has changed. Twenty years ago, large parts of the country were off-limits; today, the great majority of the country is safe for the ordinary traveller. The cities of the Andean spine — Bogotá, Medellín, Cali — are busy, modern, and have their problems, as all cities do, but they are not the cities of the headlines. The Caribbean coast — Cartagena, Santa Marta, Barranquilla, Mompox — is tourist-served and largely trouble-free. The Pacific coast, the Amazon, and the more remote parts of the Orinoquía require planning, but are not, in themselves, dangerous.

The standard advice applies. Do not walk alone at night in unfamiliar neighbourhoods. Do not display expensive cameras or jewellery in poorer areas. Do not hail taxis off the street in Bogotá — use an app, or have the hotel call one. Keep your phone in your pocket on crowded buses. The precautions are the precautions you would take in any large Latin American city. The difference is that in Colombia, the precautions work.

The afternoon heat in Cartagena is heavier than the guidebooks suggest. Do not plan anything between one and four.

For current and specific guidance, consult your own government's travel advisory — the US State Department, the UK Foreign Office, the Australian Department of Foreign Affairs — and follow their recommendations on the specific regions you plan to visit. The situation can change, particularly in the more remote rural areas and in the Pacific coast departments. The advisories are conservative; the experienced traveller calibrates accordingly.

On altitude: Bogotá is at 2,640 metres. If you are coming from sea level, you will feel it for the first day or two — a slight breathlessness, sometimes a headache. This is *soroche*, altitude sickness. Drink water. Do not drink alcohol on the first night. Take it easy. The symptoms pass within twenty-four to forty-eight hours. If you have a heart condition, consult your doctor before travelling.

On water: drink bottled or filtered water throughout Colombia, with the partial exception of Bogotá, where the tap water is generally safe. On the coast, in Mompox, and in the smaller towns, drink bottled water. The hotel provides filtered water in the rooms. Do not drink the river.

On transport: the easiest way to cover long distances is by air. Avianca is the flag carrier; LATAM, Wingo, and JetSMART offer low-cost alternatives. (Viva Air ceased operations in February 2023 — do not try to book with them.) The main airports are El Dorado, in Bogotá; José María Córdova, serving Medellín; Alfonso Bonilla Aragón, serving Cali; and Rafael Núñez, in Cartagena. Internal flights are cheap, frequent, and the only practical way to reach the Amazon (Leticia) or the Pacific coast (Nuquí, Bahía Solano).

For shorter distances, and for the slow traveller who wants to see the country, the intercity buses are excellent. The long-distance buses are comfortable, air-conditioned, and run on time. The principal companies — Expreso Bolivariano, Copetran, Berlinas del Fonce — serve the

Andean spine and the Caribbean coast. There is no rail network to speak of. The roads are good in the highlands; on the coast and in the Pacific, they are less good, and in the October rains they can flood. Plan accordingly.

Within the cities, taxis are cheap and plentiful. Uber and Cabify operate in Bogotá, Medellín, and Cali, though Uber's legal status in Colombia has been contested; if you use it, sit in the front seat, to maintain the fiction that the driver is a friend. The Transmilenio, in Bogotá, is one of the great bus-rapid-transit systems in the world — fast, cheap, and crowded.



PRACTICAL NOTES · SAFETY ON THE GROUND

SIX RULES

01 **USE HOTEL-ARRANGED TRANSPORT AT NIGHT**

In the cities, after dark, do not hail from the street. The hotel will call. The cost is the same.

02 **KEEP YOUR PHONE HIDDEN IN CROWDS**

On the Transmilenio, in the market, in the carnival. Pickpockets work where the crowds are.

03 **DON'T CARRY YOUR PASSPORT**

Carry a photocopy. Leave the original in the hotel safe.

04 **DRINK BOTTLED WATER ON THE COAST**

Bogotá tap water is fine. Elsewhere, drink bottled. The hotel provides filtered.

05 **TAKE ALTITUDE SERIOUSLY IN BOGOTÁ**

2,640 metres. Drink water, skip the first-night drink, rest if you feel the headache.

06 **CHECK THE ADVISORY FOR REMOTE AREAS**

The Pacific and Amazon regions are generally safe for prepared travellers, but the situation changes. Check before you go.



A MARKET STALL, AN AFTERNOON, THE ORDINARY
BUSINESS OF THE DAY

CHAPTER TEN

Practical Guide

X

Money, health, voltage, SIM cards, what to bring, when to come. The unromantic chapter that makes the romantic ones possible.

| *"The romance of a place is built on its plumbing."*

Colombia is, for the visitor, an easy country. The infrastructure is adequate; the people are friendly; the costs are reasonable. The following is what you need to know — the unromantic chapter that makes the romantic ones possible.

MONEY

Colombian Peso · COP

Approximately 3,350 COP to 1 USD (mid-2026). ATMs are widespread in cities; less so in smaller towns and on the coast. Carry cash for markets, taxis, and tips. Cards are widely accepted in hotels and restaurants. Tip 10% in restaurants if service is not included.

HEALTH

Vaccinations · water

Yellow fever vaccination is recommended for the Pacific, the Amazon, and the lower Magdalena. Typhoid and hepatitis A are standard. Malaria prophylaxis is recommended for the Pacific coast and the Amazon. Dengue and chikungunya are present — use repellent. Drink bottled water on the coast; Bogotá tap is fine.

PACKING

Layers, by altitude

Bogotá is cool (14–20°C year-round) — bring a jacket. Medellín is spring (18–28°C). The coast is hot (28–34°C) — light cotton, sun hat. The Pacific and Amazon are hot and wet — bring rain gear. Comfortable walking shoes for the cobblestones. Binoculars for birds. A book.

VOLTAGE

110V · 60 Hz · Type A/B

Same as North America. Type A and Type B plugs. European and UK devices need an adapter. Charging is reliable everywhere except the most remote.

WHEN TO COME

Two dry seasons

December to March is the main dry season — the best time for the Caribbean coast and the Coffee Axis. July and August are a secondary dry season in the Andes. The Pacific coast rains year-round but is driest July–October (also the whale season). The Amazon is wettest April–June.

EMERGENCIES

123 — national number

Colombia uses a single national emergency number — 123 — for police, medical, and fire. Hotel reception can arrange a doctor or pharmacy. Major cities have modern private clinics; the Fundación Santa Fe in Bogotá and the Pablo Tobón in Medellín are excellent.

INTERNET · SIM

Claro · Movistar · Tigo

Claro has the best national coverage. SIM cards are sold at airports and city shops; bring your passport. eSIM is available. WiFi is good in cities and hotels, slower in remote areas. The Pacific coast and the Amazon have very limited connectivity — this is, depending on your point of view, a feature.

AMAZON NOTES

Humidity is total

In the Amazon, paper curls. Leather molds. Leave the good watch at home. Bring ziplock bags for anything you want to keep dry.

Slow, local, respectful

Buy directly from artisans. Tip the boatmen and the guides, in cash. Ask before photographing people, especially in indigenous and Afro-Colombian communities. Do not buy wildlife products. Drones are restricted over UNESCO sites and national parks. Take your plastic with you, especially in the Amazon and the Pacific.

TIPPING

10%, or none

A 10% service charge is often added to restaurant bills — check. If not, a 10% tip is standard if service was good. Hotel staff: 2,000–5,000 COP per bag. Guides: 10–15% of the day's rate.

90 days, free, on arrival

Visitors from most Western countries (US, UK, EU, Canada, Australia) do not need a visa for stays of up to 90 days. You will receive a tourist stamp on arrival. Keep the small immigration slip — you may be asked for it on departure.



A CAFÉ, AN AFTERNOON, A CONVERSATION IN
SPANISH

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Useful Spanish

XI

A small phrasebook for the traveller. The Colombian Spanish is clear, polite, and patient with those who try.

"The Colombian accent is the Spanish that is easiest to understand, and the hardest to imitate."

Colombian Spanish — and particularly the Spanish of the interior, the *español rolo* of Bogotá — is widely considered the clearest and most neutral of the Latin American accents. It is spoken slowly, with all the consonants pronounced, and the people are patient with those who are learning. The traveller who makes the effort will be rewarded.

The phrases that follow are the ones you will actually use. The Colombian *usted* — the formal "you" — is more common than in many other Latin American countries, and is used even between strangers of the same age. Use it. *Tú* is for friends and children. *Vos*, used in parts of Argentina and Central America, is not used here.

GREETINGS & POLITENESS

<i>Buenos días</i>	Good morning	<i>¿Habla inglés?</i>	Do you speak English?
<i>Buenas tardes</i>	Good afternoon	<i>No entiendo</i>	I don't understand
<i>Buenas noches</i>	Good evening / night	<i>¿Puede repetir?</i>	Can you repeat?
<i>¿Cómo está?</i>	How are you? (formal)	<i>Más despacio, por favor</i>	More slowly, please
<i>Muy bien, gracias</i>	Very well, thank you	<i>No hablo español</i>	I don't speak Spanish
<i>Por favor</i>	Please	<i>Un momento</i>	One moment
<i>Gracias / Muchas gracias</i>	Thank you / Thank you very much	<i>Está bien</i>	It's fine / OK
<i>Con permiso</i>	Excuse me / pardon (passing)	<i>¿Qué hora es?</i>	What time is it?
<i>Con gusto</i>	You're welcome (Colombian)	<i>Mañana / Pasado mañana</i>	Tomorrow / The day after

GETTING AROUND & DAILY LIFE

<i>¿Dónde está...?</i>	Where is...?	<i>Un café, por favor</i>	A coffee, please
<i>¿Cómo llego a...?</i>	How do I get to...?	<i>Un tinto</i>	A small black coffee (Colombian)
<i>El hotel / El aeropuerto</i>	The hotel / The airport	<i>Agua sin gas / con gas</i>	Still water / sparkling
<i>El centro / La plaza</i>	The centre / The plaza	<i>La carta, por favor</i>	The menu, please
<i>Un taxi</i>	A taxi	<i>¿Qué me recomienda?</i>	What do you recommend?
<i>¿Cuánto cuesta?</i>	How much does it cost?	<i>Sin picante</i>	Not spicy
<i>¿A qué hora...?</i>	At what time...?	<i>Delicioso</i>	Delicious
<i>Estoy perdido</i>	I'm lost	<i>Necesito un médico</i>	I need a doctor
<i>La cuenta, por favor</i>	The bill, please	<i>Ayuda</i>	Help

THE SPANISH OF HERE

01 **¿QUÉ MÁS?**

The Colombian "what's up?" — used as a greeting, especially in the interior. Literally "what else?".

02 **BACANO / CHÉVERE**

"Cool", "great". *Bacano* is more interior; *chévere* more coastal.

03 **PARCERO / PARCERA**

"Mate", "friend" — Medellín and Antioquia. Very common.

04 **TINTO**

The small, sweet, dark afternoon coffee. Not the red wine of the same name.

05 **A LA ORDEN**

"At your service" — the standard reply when a shopkeeper finishes serving you. Polite, formal, and everywhere.



A SHELF, A HOTEL LIBRARY, AN AFTERNOON OF
READING AHEAD

CHAPTER TWELVE

Recommended Reading XII

A short shelf of Colombian books. For the hotel terrace, for the long bus ride, for the flight home.

| "A country is the books it has written about itself."

Colombia is a country of books, and the best way to prepare for a journey here — or to deepen one already begun — is to read. The following is a short shelf: ten books, mostly novels and memoirs, by Colombian writers, that will give a visitor a richer sense of the country than any guidebook can. All are available in English translation, though we have given the Spanish titles where they are the originals.

Cien Años de Soledad

GABRIEL GARCÍA MÁRQUEZ

1967 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS ONE HUNDRED YEARS OF SOLITUDE

The novel. The Buendía family, the town of Macondo, the hundred years of solitude. If you read one Colombian book, read this one. Macondo is, in part, Aracataca — García Márquez's birthplace, two hours from Santa Marta. It is also, in part, every small town on the Caribbean coast. Including, perhaps, Mompox.

El Amor en los Tiempos del Cólera

GABRIEL GARCÍA MÁRQUEZ

1985 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS LOVE IN THE TIME OF CHOLERA

The other great García Márquez. A love story that takes fifty-one years, nine months, and four days to resolve. The riverboat journey on the Magdalena — the second-to-last chapter — is one of the great set pieces in the literature of the river.

Crónica de una Muerte Anunciada

GABRIEL GARCÍA MÁRQUEZ

1981 · NOVELLA · TRANSLATED AS CHRONICLE OF A DEATH FORETOLD

Short, perfect, and the easiest entry into García Márquez. A murder everyone knew was coming and no one stopped. Read it in an afternoon; think about it for a year.

El Ruido de las Cosas al Caer

JUAN GABRIEL VÁSQUEZ

2011 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS THE SOUND OF THINGS FALLING

The great novel of the drug-war years — not the cartels, but the ordinary people who lived in their shadow. Bogotá in the 1990s, the hippopotamus escaped from Pablo Escobar's private zoo, the long shadow of violence on the private life. Vásquez is the great Colombian novelist of the generation after Gabo.

El Olvido que Seremos

HÉCTOR ABAD FACIOLINCE

2006 · MEMOIR · TRANSLATED AS OBLIVION: A MEMOIR

A son's memoir of his father — a doctor, a humanist, murdered by paramilitaries in Medellín in 1987. One of the indispensable books of modern Colombia. The anger and the love are inseparable. Read it before you go to Medellín.

Delirio

LAURA RESTREPO

2004 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS DELIRIUM

A literary thriller set in Bogotá in the aftermath of the drug boom. Restrepo is one of the country's finest novelists; this is her masterpiece. A woman's descent into madness, and the city around her, both explained and unexplained.

La Novela de Perón

ÁLVARO MUTIS

1903 · POETRY & PROSE · THE ADVENTURES AND MISADVENTURES OF MAQROLL

Wait — Mutis's great work is the sequence of seven novellas about Maqroll the Gaviero, the wanderer, the sailor, the eternal failure. One of the great under-read works of the late twentieth century. Mutis was García Márquez's closest friend; his prose is denser, slower, more philosophical. Start with *La Nieve del Almirante*, the first of the sequence.

Los Derrotados

PIEDAD BONNETT

2007 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS THE DEFEATED

One of the great contemporary Colombian voices. Bonnett writes of family, of love, of the quiet rooms in which the great violences of the country arrive, uninvited. Start here; read everything she has written.

La Virgen de los Sicarios

FERNANDO VALLEJO

1994 · NOVEL · TRANSLATED AS OUR LADY OF THE ASSASSINS

Difficult, brilliant, controversial. Medellín in the worst years, the killer boys, the churches, the city as a character. Not for everyone. But indispensable — there is no other book like it.

Los Caminos a Roma

GABRIEL GARCÍA MÁRQUEZ (JOURNALISM)

1999 · COLLECTED JOURNALISM

García Márquez was, before the novels, a journalist — and remained one all his life. His collected journalism is a small library in itself. *Relato de un Náufrago* (The Story of a Shipwrecked Sailor), a long reportage from 1955, is the place to start. It reads like a thriller; it is, like everything Gabo wrote, also something more.



The hotel library at Literatium has most of these. Ask at the desk. Borrow one for the terrace. The point of the trip is, in part, to have the time to read.



THE MAGDALENA AT SUNSET — THE RIVER THAT
RUNS THROUGH ALL OF COLOMBIA

CLOSING

Departure

A note on leaving Colombia. The river, the book, the slow return.

"You do not leave Colombia. You carry it out, in the colour of the river and the weight of the book."

— FROM THE HOTEL GUEST BOOK



The end of a journey to Colombia is not a single moment. It is a long, slow unwinding — the last morning on the coast, the flight back to Bogotá, the night at altitude before the long flight north, the small private sense, on the plane, that something has been understood that cannot quite be said.

What we hope you take with you: a longer view of the country than the one you arrived with. An understanding that Colombia is six countries, not one. A respect for the slowness. A small shelf of books, or the intention to build one. A plan to return.

The river, in any case, is the thread. The Magdalena runs from the páramo de las Papas, in the southern Andes, fifteen hundred kilometres north to the Caribbean. It passes through the Coffee Axis, through Honda, through Mompox, through the wetlands, to the sea. You will cross it many times, on any Colombian journey. It is the country's great artery, its great memory, its great forgetting. When you leave, you will dream of it.

"The traveller sees what he sees; the tourist sees what he has come to see. Colombia is a country for travellers."





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La Casa de las Historias

